

Ahmet Gulek CV

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Academic Positions

Stanford Immigration Policy Lab

Postdoc under the supervision of Ran Abramitzky and Jens Hainmueller
Affiliate, RFBerlin

Sept. 2025 – Present

Palo Alto, CA, USA

Education

Massachusetts Institute of Technology – MIT

PhD in Economics

Advisors: Joshua Angrist, Daron Acemoglu, Amy Finkelstein

Aug. 2019 – May 2025

Cambridge, MA, USA

M.A. Economics, Koc University

2019

B.S. Mathematics; B.A. Economics, Koc University

2017

Lycée de Galatasaray

2013

Fields of Interest

Labor Economics, Applied Econometrics, Development Economics, Spatial Economics, Public Economics

Published Papers

Driving While Hungry: The Effect of Fasting on Traffic Accidents (*Journal of Development Economics*, May 2024)

Working Papers

Long-Run Effects of H-1B Immigration on the U.S. Economy (with Ran Abramitzky, Leah Boustan, and Jens Hainmueller)

Abstract: We study the effects of H-1B immigration on U.S. industries that employ H-1B workers and their trading partners. Using a novel cross-industry design and the 1999–2003 expansion of the H-1B visa cap for identification, we find that H-1B exposure raised incomes for natives and pre-existing immigrants, with gains concentrated in non-STEM occupations. Income gains propagate forward through supply chains to downstream industries but not backward to upstream industries, consistent with a productivity shock rather than a labor supply shock. We find no direct effect on patenting, suggesting that productivity gains arise from better task execution rather than patentable invention.

Effects of Immigrants on Non-host Regions: Evidence from the Syrian Refugees in Turkey (submitted)

Abstract: This paper studies how immigration affects labor markets beyond immigrant-receiving regions through production networks. Using Turkey's Syrian refugee crisis and firm-to-firm VAT records, I show immigration shocks propagate along supply chains. Firms in non-host regions buying from host regions demand more labor; those selling to host regions increase sales. Estimates imply labor-intermediate substitution elasticity of 0.79 and inter-intermediate elasticity of 1.06. Spillovers are economically meaningful when host regions are central network nodes. A 1% labor supply increase in Istanbul decreases local real wages by 0.56% while increasing non-host wages by 0.38%. In contrast, peripheral regions generate negligible spillovers.

Formal Effects of Informal Labor: Evidence from the Syrian refugees in Turkey (submitted)

Abstract: I study the effects of Syrian refugees, who are denied work permits and thus can only work informally, on Turkish firms and workers. Using travel distance as an instrument for refugee location, I show that low-skill natives lose both informal and formal salaried jobs. I document two mechanisms: formal firms reduce their formal labor demand and new firms do not enter the formal economy. Estimates imply an elasticity of substitution of 10 between formal and informal workers. Counterfactual exercises predict that granting refugees work permits would have created up to 120,000 formal jobs in the economy through higher informal wages.

Synthetic IV estimation in panels (with Jaume Vives-i-Bastida)

Abstract: We propose a Synthetic Instrumental Variables (SIV) estimator for panel data that combines the strengths of instrumental variables and synthetic controls to address unmeasured confounding. We derive conditions under which SIV is consistent and asymptotically normal, even when the standard IV estimator is not. Motivated by the finite sample properties of our estimator,

we introduce an ensemble estimator that simultaneously addresses multiple sources of bias and provide a permutation-based inference procedure. We demonstrate the effectiveness of our methods through a calibrated simulation exercise, two shift-share empirical applications, and an application in digital economics that includes both observational data and data from a randomized control trial. In our primary empirical application, we examine the impact of the Syrian refugee crisis on Turkish labor markets. Here, the SIV estimator reveals significant effects that the standard IV does not capture. Similarly, in our digital economics application, the SIV estimator successfully recovers the experimental estimates, whereas the standard IV does not.

Formal Effects of Informal Labor Supply and Work Permits: Evidence from Venezuelan Refugees in Colombia (with Dany Bahar and Isabel di Tella)

Revise and resubmit at the *Journal of Labor Economics*

Abstract: Whether refugees should have work permits is an active policy debate. We formalize the relevant trade-offs of providing work permits to refugees and test them empirically. Our setting is the Venezuelan refugee crisis in Colombia. The keys to our analysis are (1) refugees arrive without work permits initially, and (2) Colombia started granting work permits to Venezuelans in waves. Using a shift-share design and relaxing the exogeneity of shares assumption by employing Synthetic IV à la Gulek and Vives (2023), we find that the arrival of informal refugees displaced formal and informal natives in salaried jobs, which suggests high substitutability between informal and formal labor in production. Work permits allow middle to high-skill refugees to find formal jobs and work closer to their skill level, reducing the mismatch in the economy. This comes at a cost to some natives, who lose their formal jobs, and at a benefit to others, who observe increases in salaries.

Occupational Heterogeneity of Child Penalty in the United States (submitted)

Abstract: I investigate how parenthood reshapes employment patterns across occupations and how this occupational heterogeneity contributes to earning disparities. Using a novel rotating panel approach to estimating child penalties, I document that both men and women change occupations. The well-established null effect of fatherhood hides that men's employment rate decreases in some occupations like finance and increases in others like construction. Women leave most occupations but select into occupations with part-time options. These occupational changes explain 40% of the income penalty for women, most of the income penalty for men, and most of the wage penalty for both genders.

Effect of Remote Work on the Child Penalty: Evidence from the United States (with Christina Langer) (submitted)

Abstract: We study the effect of the post-COVID expansion of remote work on the child penalty. Our empirical design proceeds in three steps: using pseudo-panels to estimate child penalties across occupations, exploiting cross-occupational variation in remote work adoption, and using synthetic controls to adjust for differential pre-COVID trajectories. Remote work reduces the hours penalty for mothers: each percentage point increase in an occupation's remote work share raises mothers' hours worked by 0.19%, eliminating one-seventh of the baseline hours penalty for the average remote occupation. We find no effects on employment, income, or wages for mothers, and no average effects on men.

Awards, Grants, and Scholarships

Best Paper Presented by a Graduate Student Award, International Association for Applied Econometrics Conference	2024
MIT Hausman Dissertation Fellowship	2023
MIT Global Seed Fund (\$26,000)	2023
MIT Shultz Fund	2022-2024
MIT Center for International Studies Summer Study Fellowship	2022-2023
Institute for Humane Studies	2023-2025
Unicredit Foundation Crivelli Europe Scholarship	2019

Teaching

14.662 Labor Economics 2 (graduate)	2025
14.41 Public Finance & Public Policy (undergraduate)	2024
14.01 Principles of Microeconomics (undergraduate)	2023
14.01 Principles of Microeconomics (undergraduate)	2021
14.64 / 14.661 Labor Economics (undergraduate/graduate)	2021

Professional Activities

Refereeing

American Economic Review: Insights, Journal of Development Economics, European Economic Review, The Economic Journal, Journal of Policy Analysis and Management

Seminars and Conferences

AEA/ASSA, Nottingham GEP Workshop, 3rd European Workshop on the Macroeconomic Implications of Migration (Rome), UC Davis Global Migration Center Seminar	2026
Barcelona Summer Forum Migration, CEPR-Rockwool Annual Labor Symposium, Society of Labor Economists, Econometric Society World Meeting, Lindau Nobel Meeting, 18th AFD-World Bank Migration and Development Conference	2025
International Association of Applied Econometrics, Society of Labor Economists, Identity & Conflict Lab at Yale, American Causal Inference Conference, IZA workshop on Labor Markets and Innovation during Times of War and Reconstruction, Bilkent University, Koc University, Ted University	2023-2024
Service	
Organizer, MIT Labor Lunch	2021-2022
Founder & Captain of MIT Economics basketball team	2019-2025

Activities and Interests

Languages: Turkish (native), English (fluent), French (intermediate)

Interests: Basketball, Argentine Tango, Salsa, Fitness, Chess